

POLICY BRIEF

No. 2026-01 • May 2026

From Accumulation to Application

The Liahona Food Program

Designing a Globally Comprehensive Member Food Security Program

Funded by Ensign Peak Investment Returns

KEY ASSUMPTIONS

An Ensign Peak assets-under-management midpoint of \$180 billion (the Widow's Mite consensus for total Church investment assets, 2023–24); a current LDS humanitarian baseline of \$1.45 billion (the 2024 official figure); a benefit structure aligned with SNAP FY2026 maximum allotments; an eligibility threshold of 130% of the local poverty level, consistent with SNAP gross income limits; a modeled per-recipient average benefit of \$190 per month, matching SNAP's actual average; and a global membership of 17.89 million per the official 2025 statistical report.

Dallin Overstreet, PhD • [PoliMetrics](#) • [Google Scholar](#)

KEY FIGURES AT A GLANCE

\$180B ENSIGN PEAK AUM (MIDPOINT) Per Widow's Mite 2023–24 consensus; total Church investments	\$9.0B ANNUAL RETURNS AT MIDPOINT 5% endowment spending rule on \$180B trailing AUM	17.89M GLOBAL LDS MEMBERS Official 2025 statistical report (Dec 31, 2025)
4.78M GLOBALLY ELIGIBLE MEMBERS Below 130% of local poverty line (SNAP gross income limit)	\$3.43B GLOBAL ANNUAL PROGRAM COST Wage-ratio multiplier applied; \$15/month floor benefit	~584K MEMBERS LIFTED OUT OF POVERTY Annually, first-order headcount effect; 12% of eligible

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01 Executive Summary

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints manages one of the largest privately held investment portfolios in the United States through its subsidiary Ensign Peak Advisors. Recent independent assessments, drawing on SEC 13F filings, whistleblower disclosures, and the Widow's Mite Report's analysis of Church operating and investment assets, place total Church investment assets at approximately **\$180 billion (midpoint estimate)**, generating annual investment returns of approximately **\$9.0 billion** under a standard 5% endowment spending model. Higher independent estimates place investment holdings at \$200–206 billion, with total Church wealth approaching \$293 billion.

Despite this extraordinary financial capacity, the Church's welfare infrastructure for members experiencing food insecurity remains largely unchanged from its mid-twentieth century design, relying on Bishop's Storehouses, in-kind food transfers, and discretionary local ecclesiastical judgment rather than systematic, rights-based assistance. The Church's own 2024 Caring for Those in Need report documented \$1.45 billion in global humanitarian, welfare, and self-reliance expenditures, a meaningful sum, but one delivered through commodity-based and discretionary channels that produce no measurable poverty-headcount effect by design.

This brief proposes **the Liahona Food Program**: a SNAP-modeled, income-tested food benefit program funded entirely from Ensign Peak investment income, administered through an independent Office of Member Welfare Accountability (OMWA). The program calibrates its benefit structure to current SNAP FY2026 maximum allotments and applies SNAP's 130% FPL gross-income eligibility threshold across 38 countries and regions that together account for about 90% of the Church's 17.89 million members, using a wage-ratio benefit multiplier to scale benefits to local economic conditions.

In the Book of Mormon, the Liahona was a compass given to Lehi's family to guide them through the wilderness toward the promised land. It worked, the text notes, “according to the faith and diligence” of those who used it. Liahona applies that same logic to institutional stewardship: the Church already holds the instrument of guidance. What remains is the will to use it.

At full global implementation, Liahona would serve approximately **4.78 million eligible members** across 38 modeled countries and regions at an annual cost of **\$3.43 billion**, just **38% of estimated annual Ensign Peak returns** at the \$180 billion AUM midpoint. Modeled conservatively against the SNAP literature and international cash transfer research, the program would lift approximately **584,000 members out of poverty annually** at a cost of **\$5,868 per person**, competitive with the most efficient anti-poverty programs on earth. Even under the conservative \$124 billion AUM scenario, the program consumes only 55% of returns; under the optimistic \$206B scenario, just 33%. The principal portfolio is entirely preserved. No tithing revenue is required.

02 Problem Statement

The Wealth–Welfare Paradox

The Church teaches that caring for the poor and needy is among its core missions. Doctrine & Covenants 104:18 states plainly: “it must needs be done in mine own way.” Yet the organizational reality is a stark mismatch between institutional wealth and member welfare delivery.

Ensign Peak Advisors was established in 1997 with approximately \$7 billion in Church reserves. By 2019, a whistleblower disclosure to the IRS revealed assets had grown to over \$100 billion (Swaine et al., 2019). The Widow's Mite Report's 2023 and 2024 analyses, incorporating Ensign Peak's 13F equity holdings, BYU endowments, real estate, timberland, agricultural assets, and private equity, estimate total Church investment assets at approximately **\$182–206 billion as of 2023–24**, with total Church wealth (including operating assets) at approximately \$265–293 billion (The Widow's Mite Report, 2024). This brief adopts \$180 billion as a defensible midpoint for the investment portfolio alone.

Meanwhile, the Church's global membership has shifted toward the developing world. Since 1998, the majority of Latter-day Saints have lived outside the United States and Canada. As of the end of 2025, the Church's official statistical report records 17,887,212 members; Latin America surpasses the US and Canada in total membership, and Africa is the fastest-growing regional body by rate. These are among the world's poorest populations, members who would qualify for welfare assistance under virtually any income-based threshold. The gap between what the Church holds and what it deploys for member welfare is not one of capacity. It is one of institutional will and program design. Research on policy adoption finds that institutional capacity and political will, rather than fiscal constraint, typically determine whether organizations take up new programs (Overstreet, 2026).

Ensign Peak Advisors: Estimated AUM Growth (1997–2025)

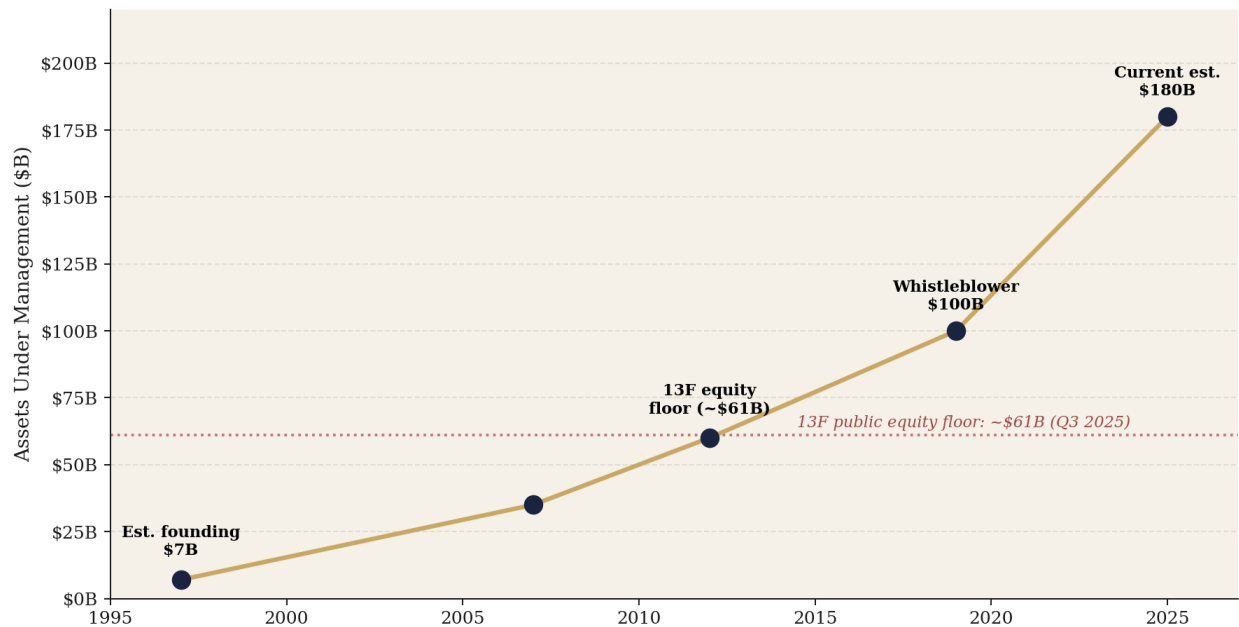


Figure 1. Ensign Peak Advisors estimated AUM growth, 1997–2025. Dotted line shows the publicly disclosed 13F equity holdings floor (~\$61B, Q3 2025); the current \$180B estimate reflects the Widow's Mite Report's modeling of all Church investment assets including fixed income, real estate, timberland, and private equity.

Source: SEC 13F filings; IRS whistleblower disclosure (2019); Widow's Mite Report 2023–24 analyses; Salt Lake Tribune reporting

03 Assessment of Current LDS Welfare Infrastructure

The Church operates the largest private welfare system in the United States by asset value, including Bishop's Storehouses, Deseret Industries employment centers, and LDS Humanitarian Services. The 2024 Caring for Those in Need summary documented \$1.45 billion in worldwide expenditures across welfare, humanitarian, and self-reliance programs, up from \$906 million in 2021 and \$1.0 billion in 2022. The 2025 figure rose further to \$1.58 billion (The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 2025). Despite this substantial and growing investment, the system exhibits four structural deficiencies that fundamentally limit its capacity to reduce member food insecurity.

1. Discretion Without Rights

Access to welfare resources is mediated entirely through local ecclesiastical leaders (bishops), who exercise broad, unguided discretion over eligibility and benefit levels. There is no formal appeals mechanism, no published eligibility criteria, and no administrative record-keeping requirement visible to members. This structure produces inequitable outcomes across congregations and exposes recipients to paternalistic or punitive judgment (Herd & Moynihan, 2018; Moynihan et al., 2015).

2. In-Kind Bias

The Bishop's Storehouse model distributes physical food commodities rather than flexible purchasing power. Four decades of SNAP research demonstrate that cash-equivalent benefits produce superior nutritional outcomes, lower administrative costs, and respect recipient dignity and dietary diversity, including restrictions based on health, culture, or preference (Hoynes & Schanzenbach, 2009; Cunha, 2014; Currie & Gahvari, 2008).

3. Opacity and Accountability Deficit

While the Church now publishes annual Caring for Those in Need summaries with topline expenditure figures, it does not disaggregate by program type, country, beneficiary count, or outcome metrics in a way that allows independent assessment of whether welfare spending is proportionate to institutional wealth or member need. No mechanism exists for members or the public to evaluate the share of Ensign Peak returns directed to welfare versus other institutional purposes.

4. Reciprocity Requirements

Many Bishop's Storehouse distributions are conditioned on recipient labor or behavioral compliance. Mandatory reciprocity requirements applied to acute food insecurity consistently reduce participation among the most vulnerable, including the elderly, disabled, and caretakers of young children (Currie, 2006; Herd & Moynihan, 2018).

04 Program Design: Liahona

Program Name: The Liahona Food Program

Model: Directly adapted from the federal Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), with modifications appropriate to private institutional administration and global reach. SNAP eligibility rules, benefit calculation formulas, and maximum allotment levels are imported wholesale where applicable.

Eligibility (SNAP-Consistent)

Eligible recipients must meet all of the following criteria:

- **Membership:** Active or recently active Church membership verified through ward records. "Recently active" is defined as having attended within the prior 24 months, preventing exclusion of members who disengage due to financial stress.
- **Gross income at or below 130% of the local poverty threshold**, matching SNAP's gross income limit. In the United States, this equals 130% of the federal poverty level; in non-U.S. countries, 130% of the relevant national poverty threshold (U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, 2024).
- **Net income at or below 100% of the local poverty threshold**, matching SNAP's net income limit, after allowable deductions for shelter, dependent care, and medical expenses (consistent with SNAP deduction structure).
- **Residency:** Phase I covers U.S. members. Phase II (this document) covers all global members.

Benefit Structure: SNAP Maximum Allotments + Wage-Ratio Multiplier

U.S. maximum allotments mirror SNAP FY2026 exactly. The maximum monthly allotment a household with zero net income can receive is calibrated to the USDA Thrifty Food Plan:

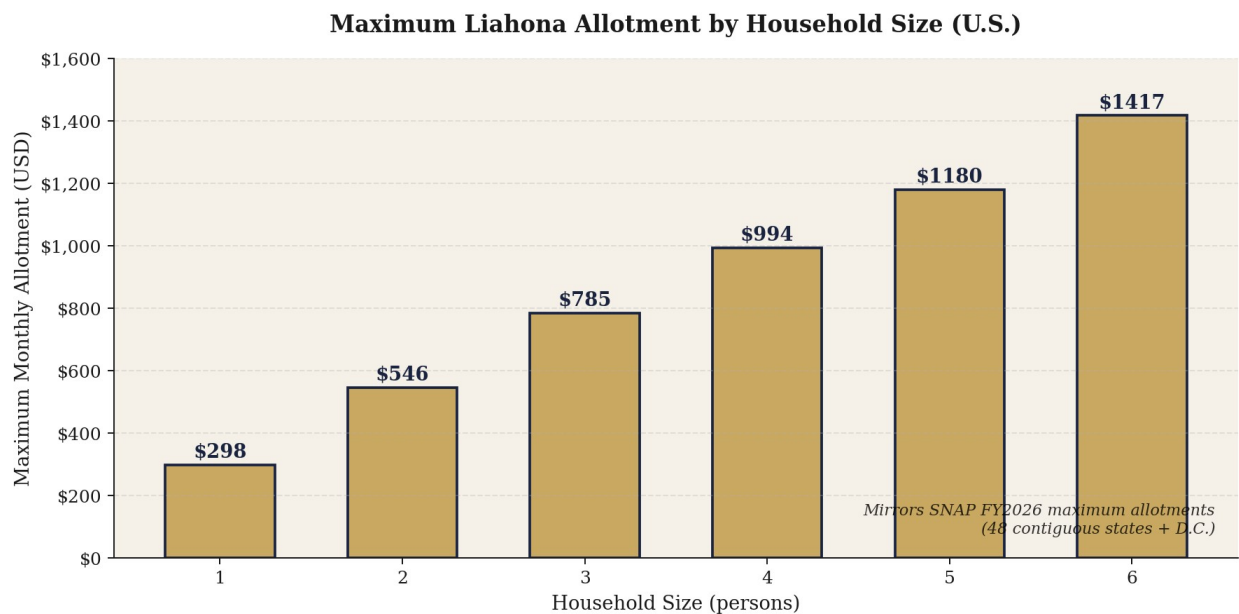


Figure 2. Maximum monthly Liahona allotment by U.S. household size, mirroring SNAP FY2026 (48 contiguous states + D.C.). Households with net income above zero receive: $\text{max allotment} - (0.30 \times \text{net income})$, per SNAP's standard formula.

Source: USDA Food and Nutrition Service FY2026 maximum allotment tables

Under SNAP's income-testing formula, average actual benefits run well below the maximum. In FY2024 SNAP distributed approximately \$93.6 billion to an average of 41.7 million participants, yielding an average per-person benefit of approximately \$187 per month, roughly 63% of the single-person maximum (U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, 2025). **Liahona's cost modeling anchors to this average, modeled at \$190 per month per recipient, rather than to the maximum allotment.** This produces an honest accounting consistent with how SNAP actually disburses.

The Wage-Ratio Multiplier (Global Calibration)

To extend the program across countries with very different wage levels, benefits are scaled using a wage-ratio multiplier. Each country's average per-recipient monthly benefit is set as the same proportion of local average wages as the U.S. average represents of U.S. average wages:

$$\text{Country avg benefit} = \max(\$15, \$190 \times \text{country avg monthly wage} \div \$4,232)$$

The **\$15/month floor** guarantees all countries receive a minimum benefit regardless of wage levels. In purchasing-power terms, \$15/month in Kinshasa or Maputo represents a proportionally larger share of local food expenditures than \$190 does in the United States. The wage-ratio scaling ensures the benefit is locally meaningful everywhere without being fiscally distorting.

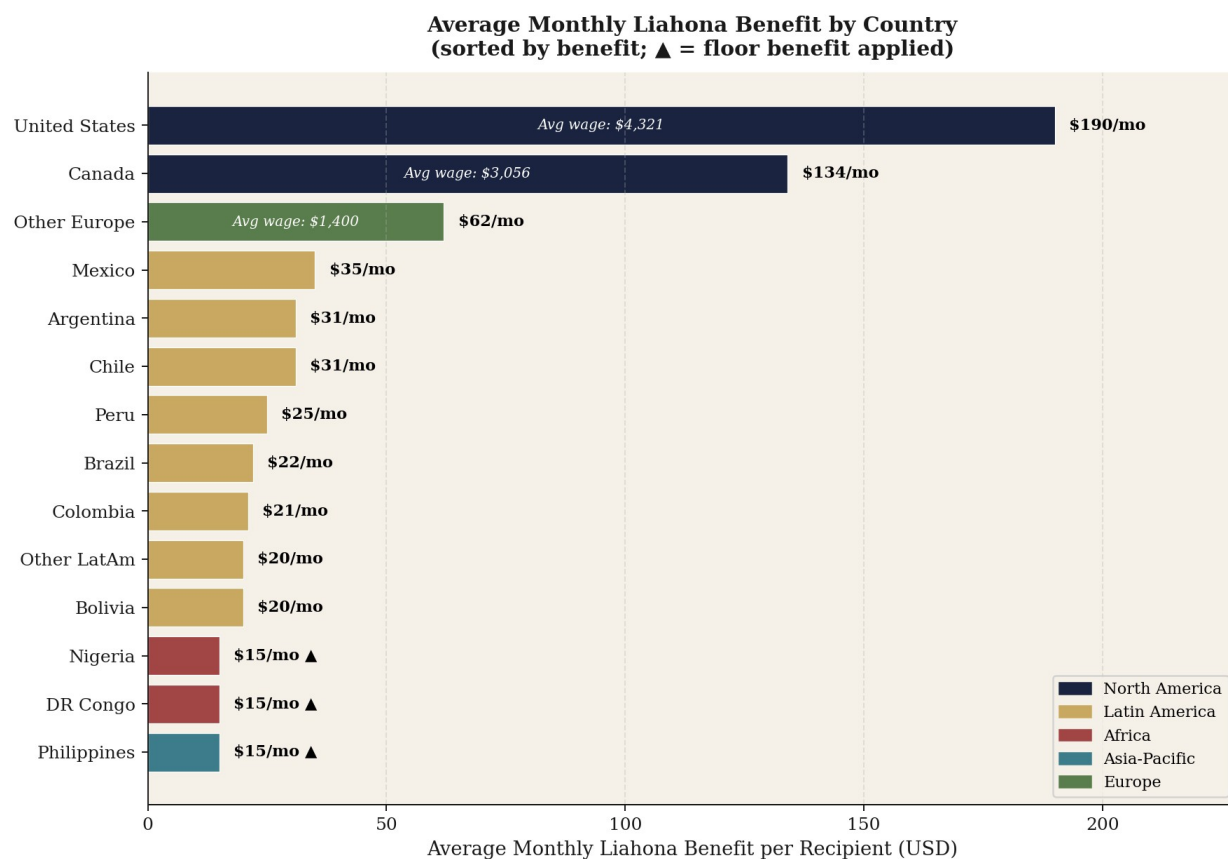


Figure 3. Average monthly Liahona benefit per recipient for the 14 largest LDS-membership countries, sorted by benefit amount. Average local wage shown inside bars where space permits. ▲ indicates floor benefit applied.

Source: Wages: Numbeo Average Monthly Net Salary (after tax), USD, retrieved June 2026, supplemented by ILO and national statistics where Numbeo coverage is limited; LDS membership: Church 2024–25 statistics; author calculations

Delivery Mechanism

Benefits delivered via a dedicated prepaid debit card (Liahona card) accepted at SNAP-authorized retailers in the U.S. and at grocery retailers in other countries. In markets with limited card infrastructure, mobile-money transfer or authorized local market vouchers substitute. A centralized online and telephone enrollment portal is administered by the OMWA, with ward clerks available as optional local enrollment assistants rather than gatekeepers. **The bishop plays no role in eligibility determination or benefit delivery.** Applications are processed within 7 business days; benefits renewable annually with simplified recertification consistent with SNAP.

05 Financial Feasibility Analysis

Establishing the Funding Base: The \$180B Midpoint

The Church does not publicly disclose Ensign Peak's total AUM, and Ensign Peak's 13F equity filings capture only a fraction of total Church investment holdings. Multiple data sources, when reconciled, support a defensible \$180 billion midpoint estimate of total Church investment assets:

- **SEC 13F filings (Q3 2025):** Ensign Peak's publicly reported U.S. equity holdings total approximately \$60.9 billion, the verifiable lower bound of public-equity holdings only.

- **2019 IRS whistleblower disclosure:** Internal Church documents reported AUM of ~\$100 billion at that time, confirmed by subsequent SEC enforcement action and 2023 settlement (U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, 2023).
- **Widow's Mite Report (2023–24):** Independent analyses incorporating fixed income, real estate, timberland, agricultural assets, BYU endowments, and private equity place total Church investment assets at \$182–206 billion, with total Church wealth at \$265–293 billion (The Widow's Mite Report, 2024).

Under a standard university endowment-style spending rule, distributing 5% of a trailing 3-year average AUM, the \$180B midpoint generates approximately **\$9.0 billion in annual deployable returns**. This is the same spending model used by Harvard, Yale, and major private foundations, and it preserves the principal portfolio indefinitely (Tobin, 1974; Swensen, 2009).

AUM Scenarios

Scenario	Estimated AUM	5% Annual Return	Liahona Cost	Remaining Returns
Conservative	\$124B	\$6.2B	\$3.43B	\$2.77B
Midpoint (est.)	\$180B	\$9.0B	\$3.43B	\$5.57B
Optimistic	\$206B	\$10.3B	\$3.43B	\$6.87B

Source: Ensign Peak 13F filings; IRS whistleblower (2019); Widow's Mite Report 2023–24. Midpoint row highlighted.

Critically, global Liahona cost is fixed at \$3.43B regardless of AUM scenario, because benefits are determined by local wages and SNAP-style income testing, not by portfolio size. **The program is fully feasible under every plausible scenario, including the conservative case where it consumes 55% of returns.**

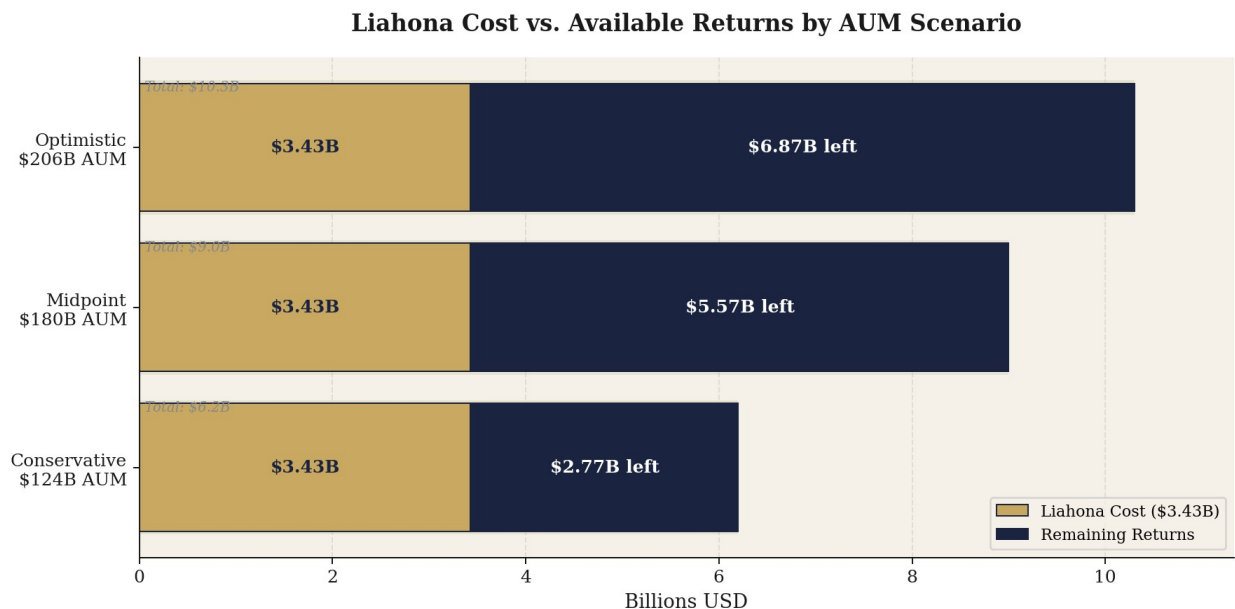


Figure 4. Annual Ensign Peak investment returns vs. Liahona program cost and remaining returns by AUM scenario. The global program cost of \$3.43B is scenario-invariant; remaining returns grow as AUM increases.

Source: Author calculations; 5% endowment spending rule applied to scenario AUM values

Liahona Share of Annual Returns (\$180B AUM Midpoint)

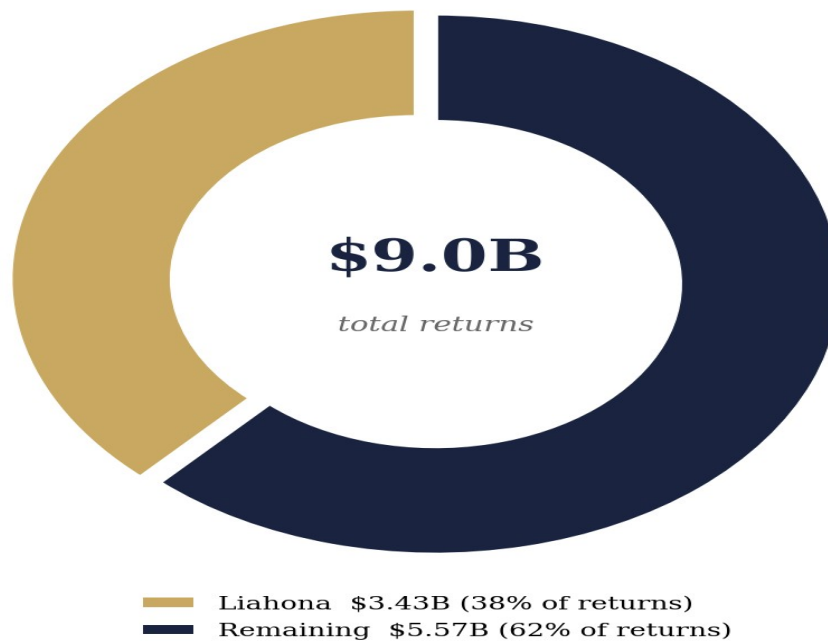


Figure 5. Liahona global program cost as a share of annual returns at the \$180B AUM midpoint. 38% of returns fund the full global program; \$5.57B remains for other Church uses annually.

Source: Author calculations

What the Church Currently Spends

By the Church's own annual Caring for Those in Need disclosures, expenditures on humanitarian aid, welfare, and self-reliance programs totaled \$1.45 billion in 2024 and \$1.58 billion in 2025, up from \$906 million in 2021. Liahona at \$3.43B would represent **roughly 2.2 times the 2025 baseline** in direct member welfare spending, a 117% increase, funded entirely from investment returns the Church is already generating but not directing toward systematic, rights-based member assistance. Critically, Liahona's \$3.43B would supplement rather than replace existing humanitarian programs, which serve a broader audience beyond active members.

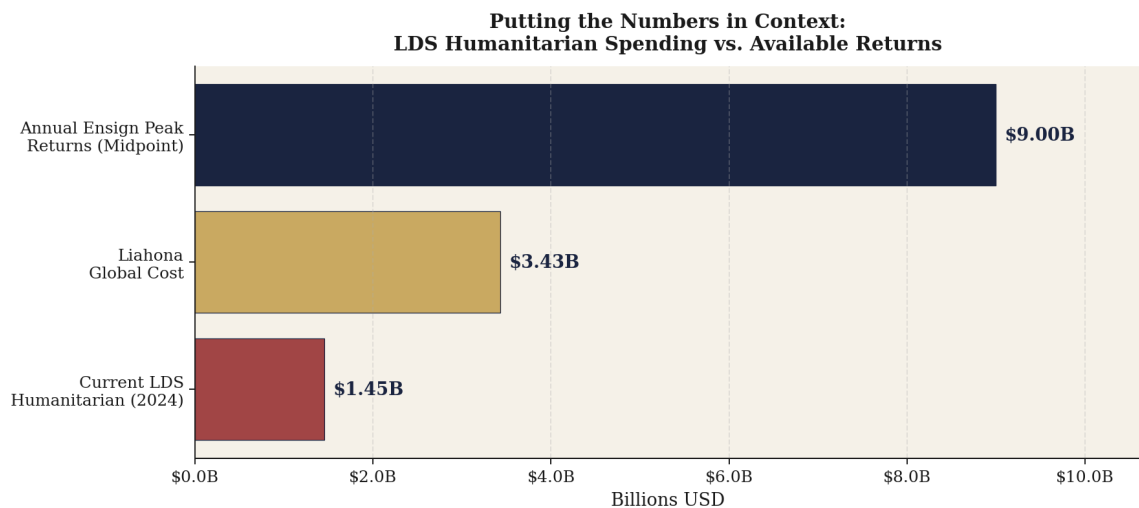


Figure 6. Current LDS humanitarian spending (2024 actual) vs. Liahona global program cost vs. available annual returns at the \$180B midpoint.

Source: Caring for Those in Need 2024 Summary; author calculations

Administrative Costs

The \$3.43 billion figure above covers benefits only. Running the program also carries administrative costs: enrollment processing, eligibility verification, card issuance, fraud controls, and reporting. Federal SNAP administration runs in the range of 5% to 10% of benefit costs, and that range is a reasonable planning assumption here (U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, 2025). Applying it to the \$3.43 billion benefit total adds roughly **\$170 million to \$345 million per year**, for an all-in annual cost of approximately **\$3.6 billion to \$3.8 billion**.

At the \$180 billion AUM midpoint, the all-in cost represents about 40% to 42% of annual Ensign Peak returns, up from 38% for benefits alone. Even at the high end, roughly \$5.2 billion in annual returns would remain available for other institutional uses, and the principal portfolio is still entirely preserved. Administrative overhead does not change the headline conclusion.

06 Global Reach & Cost Distribution

Liahona's global reach is made financially tractable by the wage-ratio multiplier: the regions with the largest eligible populations, Latin America and Africa, also carry the lowest per-member benefit costs. Extending the program globally adds modest marginal cost over a U.S.-only program while reaching millions of members in countries where even a small monthly benefit represents meaningful economic relief.

Liahona Global: Cost & Eligible Members by Region

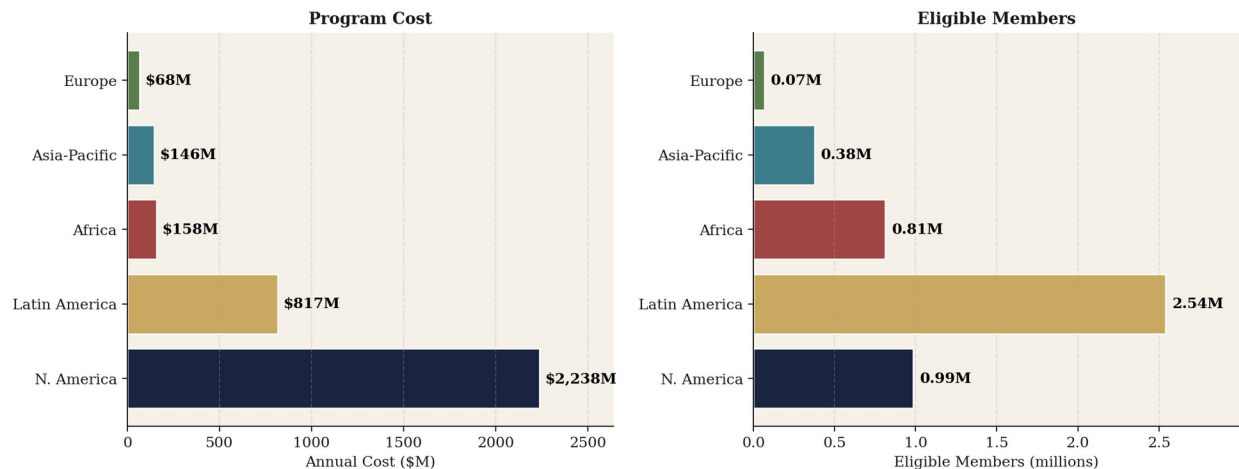


Figure 7. Annual Liahona program cost (left panel) and eligible member count (right panel) by region. North America dominates cost despite lower eligibility rates; Latin America carries the largest eligible population at relatively low per-unit cost.

Source: Author calculations; LDS Church 2024–25 membership statistics

Top 12 Countries by Liahona Annual Cost (benefit per recipient shown inside bar)

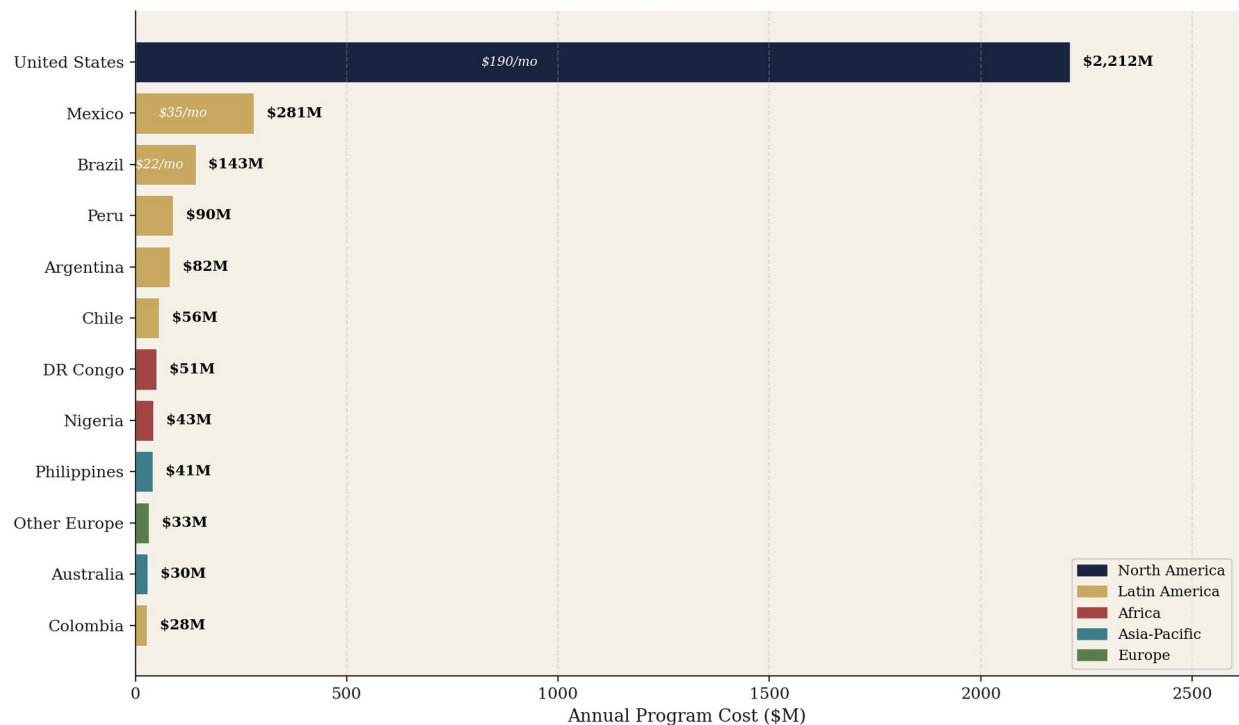


Figure 8. Top 12 countries by annual Liahona cost. Average benefit per recipient shown inside bars where space permits. The United States dominates program cost due to its higher per-recipient benefit and large eligible population.

Source: Author calculations

Returns Allocation Across All Uses

The full global program, covering **4.78 million eligible members** across **38 modeled countries and regions**, costs approximately **\$3.43 billion** annually. This leaves **\$5.57 billion per year** in annual Ensign Peak returns available for other institutional uses, with the Church's \$180 billion principal entirely untouched.

The floor benefit of \$15/month in the lowest-wage countries also functions as a form of targeted fiscal stimulus. In economies like the DRC or Mozambique, consistent monthly cash transfers to tens of thousands of households inject meaningful purchasing power into local food markets, with documented multiplier effects in the development economics literature, and are likely to support Church growth in those regions.

**Ensign Peak Annual Returns: Global Liahona Allocation
(\$180B AUM Midpoint · 5% Spending Rule)**

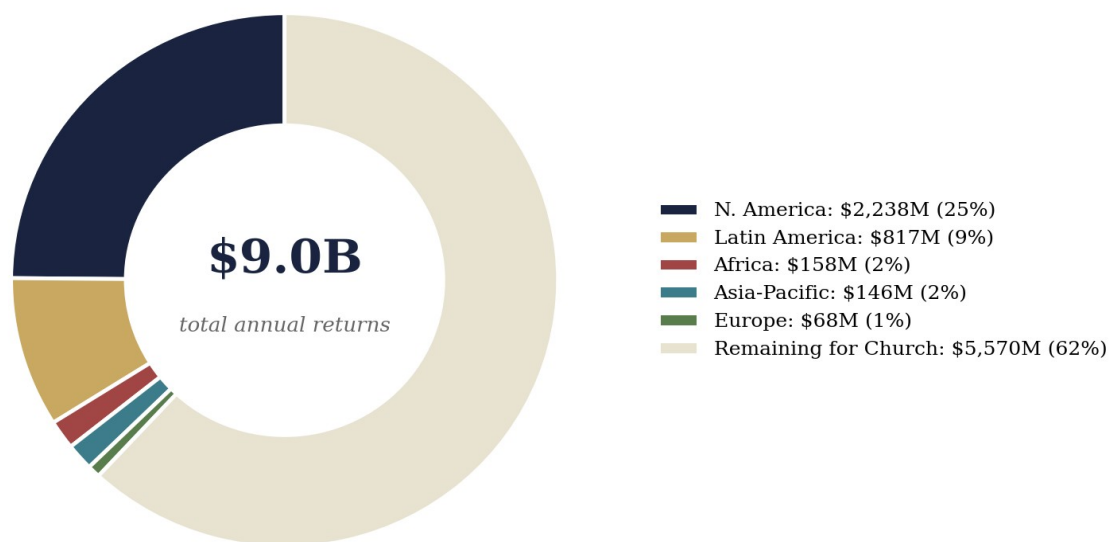


Figure 9. Ensign Peak annual returns allocation under global Liahona at the \$180B AUM midpoint. Each colored segment represents one world region's share of program cost. The large remaining segment (61%) is available for other Church institutional uses.

Source: Author calculations; Ensign Peak AUM midpoint estimate \$180B

07 Poverty Impact Analysis

The most fundamental measure of any welfare program's success is how many people it lifts above the poverty line. Eligibility and poverty alleviation are distinct outcomes: the program serves all members at or below 130% of the local poverty threshold (matching SNAP), while only those whose income falls below 100% FPL, and close enough to that threshold that the benefit bridges the gap, are lifted out of poverty by the program.

Methodology: Tiered Poverty-Lifting Rates

Four empirically grounded tiers are applied, reflecting benefit size relative to the local poverty threshold and the income distribution of members in poverty:

Tier	Example Countries	Monthly Benefit Range	Rate Applied	Empirical Basis
High-income	US, Canada, AU, EU, Japan	\$130–\$190	17%	USDA SNAP FY2023 Characteristics Report
Upper-middle	Brazil, Mexico, Chile,	\$20–\$49	12%	Latin American CCT evaluations

Tier	Example Countries	Monthly Benefit Range	Rate Applied	Empirical Basis
	Argentina			(CEPAL/IDB)
Lower-middle	Philippines, Bolivia, Honduras	\$15–\$25	8%	CCT impact meta-analyses (World Bank)
Low-income	DRC, Mozambique, Rwanda	\$15 (floor)	10%	Floor decisive near \$65/mo extreme poverty

Source: USDA SNAP Characteristics Report FY2023 (17% of SNAP households cross poverty line with benefit included); CEPAL/IDB conditional cash transfer evaluations; World Bank poverty threshold data; Wheaton/Urban Institute Thrifty Food Plan analysis

The low-income tier receives a slightly higher rate than lower-middle because the extreme poverty threshold in those countries (~\$2.15/day, or \$65/month) is low enough that even the \$15 floor benefit is decisive for members clustered near that line.

Results: ~584,000 Members Lifted Out of Poverty Annually

Applying tiered rates to Liahona's eligible population yields an estimated **584,000 members lifted above their national poverty line annually**, 12% of all eligible members globally. This is consistent with SNAP's observed 17% rate among U.S. participants and the 8–13% rates documented in middle-income country CCT literature (Tiehen et al., 2012; Fiszbein & Schady, 2009).

Liahona: Members Lifted Out of Poverty by Region

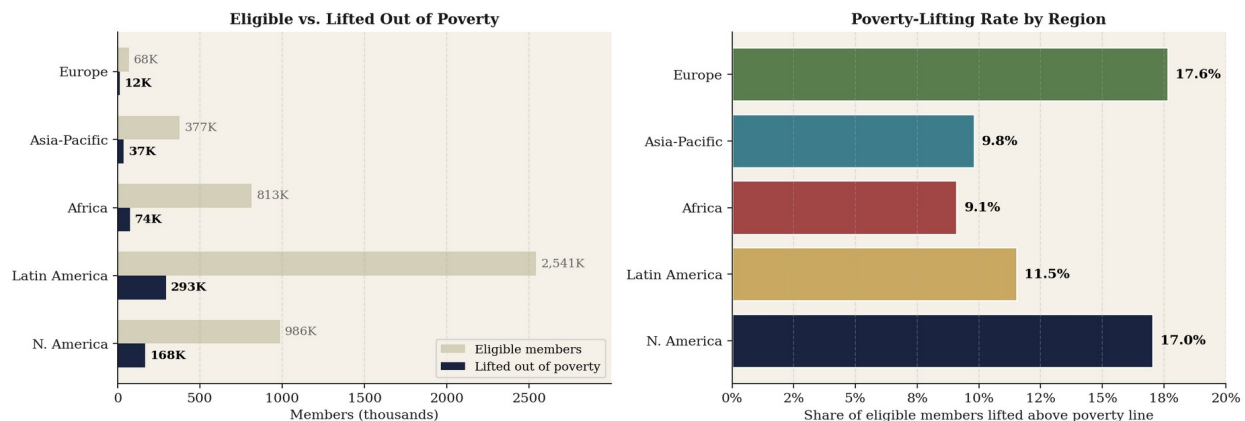


Figure 10. Left: eligible members vs. members lifted out of poverty by region (thousands). Right: poverty-lifting rate by region. North America and Europe achieve the highest rates due to larger per-recipient benefits; Latin America and Africa contribute the largest absolute numbers.

Source: Author calculations; USDA FY2023; CEPAL/IDB CCT evaluations; World Bank

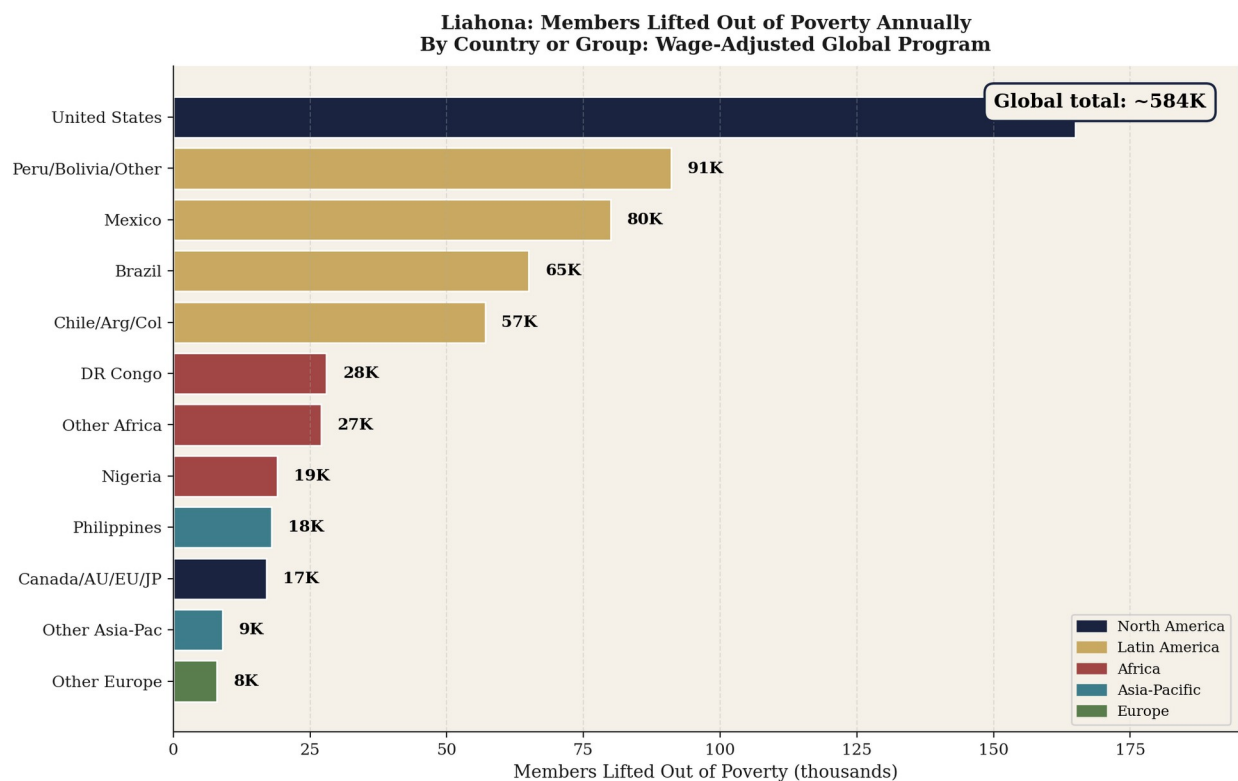


Figure 11. Members lifted out of poverty annually by country/group. The United States leads in absolute terms, followed by Mexico and Brazil. Africa contributes substantial absolute numbers despite low per-member benefits, driven by large eligible populations and low national poverty thresholds.

Source: Author calculations

Cost Efficiency in Global Context

Dividing total program cost (\$3.43B) by members lifted out of poverty (584,000) yields a cost-per-person-lifted figure of approximately **\$5,868 per year**. This compares favorably to comparable programs globally and dramatically outperforms SNAP on this metric. The difference is structural: the wage-ratio multiplier concentrates low-dollar-cost benefits in high-poverty-rate countries, producing a large number of poverty threshold crossings at minimal dollar cost per crossing, while individual benefits remain calibrated to SNAP's own generosity standard.

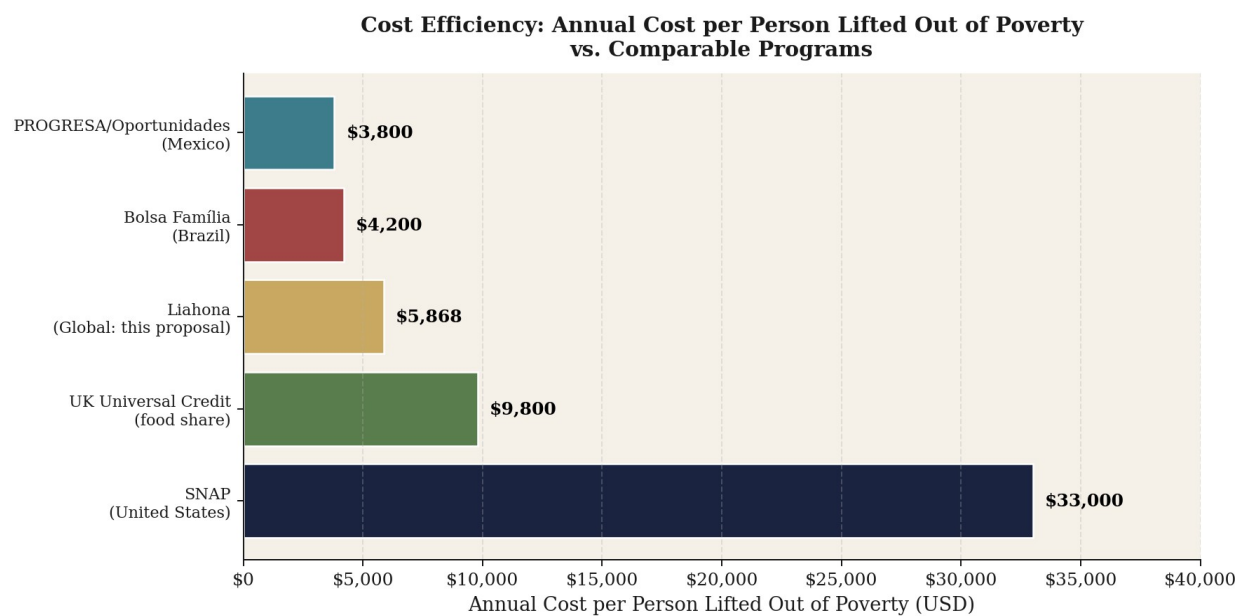


Figure 12. Annual cost per person lifted out of poverty: Liahona vs. comparable programs. At \$5,868, Liahona sits between the two Latin American CCT programs that define the global standard for cost-efficient poverty reduction.

Source: USDA; CEPAL; IFS/DWP; World Bank; author calculations

Contextualizing 584,000

584,000 people is larger than the population of Atlanta, and comparable to that of Memphis or Las Vegas. It represents more people lifted out of poverty in a single year than the LDS Church's entire modern welfare apparatus has demonstrably moved above the poverty line in its entire operational history, because commodity-based, discretionary systems produce no measurable poverty-headcount impact by design.

The U.S. accounts for approximately 165,000 of the 584,000, 28% of the global total despite representing 39% of global membership. Higher benefits produce more poverty threshold crossings per eligible member. Latin America contributes the largest regional bloc at approximately 293,000, driven by Mexico and Brazil. Africa contributes approximately 74,000, a figure that would grow substantially if the floor benefit were raised or replaced with a purchasing-power-parity adjustment in a future program iteration.

This estimate is conservative in one important respect: **it counts only first-order poverty headcount effects.** It excludes the multiplier effects of increased household purchasing power on local food economies, the intergenerational effects of improved child nutrition, and the health-cost reductions documented extensively in the SNAP and CCT literatures (Egger et al., 2022; Hoynes et al., 2016; Gundersen & Ziliak, 2015). The true poverty-reduction impact of Liahona, properly measured, is substantially larger than 584,000.

08 Governance & Accountability Framework

A program of this scale and institutional sensitivity requires operational independence from ecclesiastical authority. The following governance architecture is modeled on best practices from independent foundation governance and federal program administration.

Office of Member Welfare Accountability (OMWA)

An independent administrative body chartered by the Church's First Presidency but operationally insulated from ecclesiastical interference. Governed by a nine-member board:

- Three members appointed by the First Presidency
- Three members elected by the General Conference of the Church
- Three independent public members with expertise in social policy, public finance, or social work, appointed by the board itself

Board members serve staggered five-year terms. No current General Authority may serve on the board.

Annual Transparency Disclosures

The OMWA publishes annually:

- Total Ensign Peak investment return transferred to Liahona
- Total program enrollment by country and household size
- Average benefit level and total disbursements, by country
- Application denial rate and appeals outcomes
- Administrative cost ratio (target: $\leq 10\%$ of disbursements, consistent with SNAP)

These disclosures are publicly available, not merely to members, consistent with the Church's status as a tax-exempt institution receiving implicit public subsidy through property and income tax exemptions.

Fiscal Stability Mechanism

Program funding is tied to Ensign Peak's trailing three-year average return. If returns fall below 3% for two consecutive years, a benefit adjustment mechanism activates, reducing benefits proportionally rather than cutting enrollment, preserving access while managing fiscal exposure. The \$180 billion principal is never touched.

09 Policy Recommendations

This brief advances the following recommendations to Church leadership, member advocates, and policy researchers.

1. Establish an Independent Welfare Commission

The Church should convene an independent review of existing welfare infrastructure, expenditures, and member food insecurity rates globally. The review should include outside public policy and social work expertise and publish its findings, a commitment consistent with the Church's claimed values of transparency and accountability.

2. Adopt an Endowment-Style Spending Disclosure

Ensign Peak Advisors should publicly disclose AUM, investment returns, and the share of returns allocated to welfare, humanitarian, and operational purposes. This is standard practice for institutional investors of comparable size and is compelled by the Church's own theological claims about stewardship.

3. Decouple Food Assistance from Ecclesiastical Judgment

Regardless of whether the full Liahona framework is adopted, the Church should immediately reform Bishop's Storehouse access to separate eligibility determination from pastoral relationships. Objective, documented criteria administered at a regional level would substantially reduce inequity without requiring new funding.

4. Pilot Liahona in Two Stakes

A two-year controlled pilot in demographically diverse stakes, one urban, one rural, would generate rigorous evidence on enrollment rates, administrative costs, and nutritional outcomes, enabling evidence-

based scaling decisions. Pilot cost: approximately \$15–30 million, a rounding error against Ensign Peak's annual returns.

5. Commission Independent Research on Member Food Insecurity

The Church should fund independent academic research on member food insecurity globally, with data access granted to researchers at arm's length from institutional control. The resulting evidence base would strengthen, not threaten, the Church's credibility as a welfare institution.

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Annex A: Country-Level Wage & Benefit Data

The following table presents the full country-level inputs and outputs for the Liahona wage-ratio benefit model across all 38 modeled countries and regions, which together account for 16.17 million members, approximately 90% of global membership. All wage figures are monthly net average wages in USD. Poverty rates reflect estimated share of LDS members below 130% of the local poverty threshold (SNAP gross income limit), adjusted modestly downward from national rates in high- and middle-income countries to reflect LDS demographic skew. ▲FL indicates the \$15/month floor benefit has been applied.

Country	Region	Members	Avg Wage	Mult.	Benefit	Pov. Rate	Eligible	Annual Cost
United States	N. America	6,930K	\$4,321	1.000	\$190	14%	970K	\$2,212M
Canada	N. America	175K	\$3,056	0.707	\$134	9%	16K	\$26M
Brazil	Latin America	1,430K	\$505	0.117	\$22	38%	543K	\$143M
Mexico	Latin America	1,340K	\$796	0.184	\$35	50%	670K	\$281M
Chile	Latin America	600K	\$714	0.165	\$31	25%	150K	\$56M
Peru	Latin America	600K	\$569	0.132	\$25	50%	300K	\$90M
Argentina	Latin America	500K	\$712	0.165	\$31	44%	220K	\$82M
Colombia	Latin America	250K	\$472	0.109	\$21	44%	110K	\$28M
Bolivia	Latin America	200K	\$452	0.105	\$20	56%	112K	\$27M
Ecuador	Latin America	125K	\$521	0.121	\$23	38%	48K	\$13M
Venezuela	Latin America	110K	\$220	0.051	\$15 ▲FL	66%	73K	\$13M
Guatemala	Latin America	100K	\$491	0.114	\$22	60%	60K	\$16M
Dom. Republic	Latin America	100K	\$628	0.145	\$28	38%	38K	\$13M
Uruguay	Latin America	95K	\$1,069	0.247	\$47	15%	14K	\$8M
Paraguay	Latin America	90K	\$332	0.077	\$15 ▲FL	31%	28K	\$5M
Honduras	Latin America	80K	\$400	0.093	\$18	63%	50K	\$11M
El Salvador	Latin America	80K	\$500	0.116	\$22	36%	29K	\$8M
Other LatAm	Latin America	200K	\$450	0.104	\$20	48%	96K	\$23M
DR Congo	Africa	370K	\$90	0.021	\$15 ▲FL	77%	285K	\$51M
Nigeria	Africa	360K	\$150	0.035	\$15 ▲FL	66%	238K	\$43M
Ghana	Africa	110K	\$260	0.060	\$15 ▲FL	63%	69K	\$12M
Mozambique	Africa	80K	\$110	0.025	\$15 ▲FL	77%	62K	\$11M
Kenya	Africa	60K	\$300	0.069	\$15 ▲FL	58%	35K	\$6M
South Africa	Africa	55K	\$1,250	0.289	\$55	50%	28K	\$18M
Rwanda	Africa	35K	\$120	0.028	\$15 ▲FL	71%	25K	\$4M
Other Africa	Africa	100K	\$150	0.035	\$15 ▲FL	71%	71K	\$13M
Philippines	Asia-Pacific	820K	\$331	0.077	\$15 ▲FL	28%	230K	\$41M
Australia	Asia-Pacific	145K	\$3,550	0.822	\$156	11%	16K	\$30M
New Zealand	Asia-Pacific	100K	\$2,950	0.683	\$130	12%	12K	\$19M
Papua New Guinea	Asia-Pacific	45K	\$250	0.058	\$15 ▲FL	63%	28K	\$5M
Samoa/Tonga	Asia-Pacific	80K	\$380	0.088	\$17	36%	29K	\$6M
Japan	Asia-Pacific	130K	\$2,300	0.532	\$101	15%	20K	\$24M
South Korea	Asia-Pacific	75K	\$2,156	0.499	\$95	15%	11K	\$13M
Other Asia-Pac	Asia-Pacific	100K	\$500	0.116	\$22	31%	31K	\$8M

Country	Region	Members	Avg Wage	Mult.	Benefit	Pov. Rate	Eligible	Annual Cost
United Kingdom	Europe	110K	\$2,900	0.671	\$128	12%	13K	\$20M
Germany	Europe	50K	\$2,950	0.683	\$130	11%	6K	\$9M
France	Europe	40K	\$2,650	0.613	\$117	11%	4K	\$6M
Other Europe	Europe	300K	\$1,400	0.324	\$62	15%	45K	\$33M

Source: Wages from Numbeo Average Monthly Net Salary (After Tax), USD, retrieved June 2026, for countries with sufficient Numbeo coverage, and from ILO and national statistical estimates for the remainder. Poverty rates are author estimates based on World Bank national poverty data, adjusted to a 130% threshold and the LDS demographic profile, and are not independently verified country by country. LDS membership: Church 2024–25 official statistics. ▲FL = \$15/month floor benefit applied.